90-Day Cybersecurity Quick-Start Guide

Cohort 3: IT Professionals

Goal: Pivot from your current IT role into security-focused work by leveraging your existing environment, building visible security contributions, and creating a clear transition path.

Time commitment: 5–8 hours/week (realistic around current job)

Days 1–30: Observe & Align

Study Focus

- Security fundamentals in context of systems you already manage
- Blue-team workflows and SOC operations overview
- How security shows up in your current role (tickets, reviews, incidents)

Environment Mapping

- Document where logs come from in your organization
- Identify monitoring/alerting/SIEM tools currently in use
- Map how incidents are handled and who owns security
- Have 1–2 conversations with security stakeholders

Lab Goals

- Create a home lab mirroring one work-like system
- Enable logging and practice basic queries (who logged in, from where, what ran)
- Use native tools or free SIEM to ingest home lab logs

Success Metrics

- ✓ High-level map of org's logging and incident flows
- ✓ Home lab reflecting at least one production-like system
- ✓ Clarity on target direction (SOC/IR, cloud security, AppSec, SecEng)
- ✓ At least one security contact in your organization

Days 31–60: Contribute & Specialize

Choose Your Track Based on Current Role

Track A: Helpdesk / Sysadmin

- Study: OS hardening guides, patch/vulnerability management basics
- Project: Baseline a system, apply hardening, simulate misuse, confirm detection
- Output: Before/after hardening doc + playbook for one common issue

Track B: Developer / DevOps

- Study: Secure coding basics (OWASP Top 10), CI/CD security
- Project: Add security logging to app, add pipeline checks (SAST, dependency scan)
- Output: "Security improvements I added to [app/pipeline] and why they matter"

Track C: Cloud / Platform

- Study: Provider security (IAM, logging, network security), best practices
- Project: Build sandbox environment, introduce misconfigs, fix them, document findings
- Output: Mini security review (findings + remediations + policy recommendations)

Career Actions

- Tell your manager and security leaders about your interest
- Ask about formal/informal paths into security (secondments, rotations)
- Demonstrate capability with one key security tool or process

Success Metrics

✓ At least one completed security-related improvement or project
✓ Visible contribution to security in your current environment
✓ Explicit communication of transition interest to stakeholders

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Days 61–90: Own & Transition

Study Focus

- Deeper blue-team topics: detection engineering, automation, advanced concepts
- Benchmark yourself against 90-day SOC/defender roadmaps
- Identify medium-term learning target (cert, domain, specialization)

Ownership Project

- Take ongoing responsibility for a specific security task or mini-domain
- Examples: monthly patch review, log dashboards, pipeline security checks, secure defaults
- Create or improve documentation and runbooks around that area
- Define basic metrics (open vulns over time, failed logins, scan results)
- Optionally automate a small part (script, scheduled query, CI/CD step)

Transition Planning

- Explore internal role changes, secondments, or joint responsibilities
- If internal transition isn't possible, prepare external portfolio (anonymize as needed)
- Document all security contributions clearly
- Build concrete 6–12 month development plan

Success Metrics

✓ Documented "mini security domain" you own with clear value
✓ Short deck or one-pager showing security work to hiring managers
✓ Concrete path (internal or external) toward security-focused role
✓ Ongoing development plan for next 6–12 months

Key Resources

Platforms: Blue Team Labs Online, Hack The Box Academy (SOC/DFIR), cloud provider security centers (AWS/Azure/GCP skill builder)

Practical focus: Detection engineering blogs, MITRE ATT&CK for defenders, provider-specific security best practices

Community: Local cloud/DevOps/security meetups, r/cybersecurity mentorship threads, internal security guilds/chapters

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Quick Wins Checklist

Week	Milestone
Week 2	Environment mapping complete
Week 4	Home lab running, first security conversation done
Week 6	First security-focused project scoped
Week 8	Project delivered, documented
Week 10	Ownership domain defined and running
Week 12	Transition conversation with manager, portfolio ready

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Internal Transition Advantages

You already have **significant advantages** over external candidates:

- **Context:** You know the systems, tools, processes, and people
- **Trust:** You've already proven yourself to the organization
- **Access:** You can contribute to security immediately in your current role
- **Visibility:** Your security work is seen by the people who make hiring decisions
- **Lower risk:** Internal moves are easier to negotiate and test (secondments, splits)

Strategy: Make yourself the "security go-to" in your current team before asking for a formal role change. Once you're solving security problems regularly, the title change becomes a formality.

Role-Specific Quick Paths

- **Helpdesk → SOC Analyst:** Focus on log analysis, alert triage, basic IR
- **Sysadmin → Security Engineer:** Focus on hardening, automation, detection
- **Network Admin → Network Security:** Focus on firewall rules, segmentation, monitoring
- **Developer → AppSec:** Focus on secure coding, SAST/DAST, pipeline security
- **DevOps → Cloud Security:** Focus on IaC security, cloud-native controls, CSPM

- **Platform Engineer → Detection Engineer:** Focus on log pipelines, correlation, automation

Remember: You don't need to start over. You need to angle your existing expertise toward security outcomes.

Next step: Fill out your intake questions and complete your environment mapping using the detailed guide in your cohort folder.